

battery life, whereas some expensive ones use up a charge quickly.

Some examples of the available batteries are high-capacity disposable CRV3s, proprietary rechargeable batteries, non-rechargeable alkaline batteries and rechargeable nickel metal hydride (NiMH). Batteries such as alkaline batteries might get drained pretty quickly, which could turn out to be quite expensive.

Viewfinders

A DSLR camera features an optical viewfinder which displays the exact image that the camera lens is capturing. But, it is worth mentioning that not all are created equal.

DSLRs come with three basic types of viewfinders, namely, optical viewfinder, electronic viewfinder and an LCD screen with a live view. You need to make sure that the camera's viewfinder is bright, you are able to see edge-to-edge and that the focusing screen is clear.

You also need to pay attention to magnification and coverage numbers for pentaprism finders, as these give you an idea of the actual size of the finder and how much of the captured image can be viewed.

Megapixels

Talking about the role played by megapixels in a camera, you should know that a high megapixel count does not necessarily mean better image quality. Though, high megapixels give you more flexibility when cropping or making enlargements. But, a higher megapixel count produces larger files, which, in turn, take up more space.

Many DSLR cameras today exceed 13MP, which enables creative zooming in and cropping of images. A 5MP image is enough to make a sharp 20.3cm-by-25.4cm (8-inch-by-10-inch) print and an 8MP image is enough to make a sharp 27.9cm-by-35.6cm (11-inch-by-14-inch) print.

Sensors

An image sensor detects and conveys the information that constitutes an

image. It does so by converting the variable attenuation of light waves into electrical signals, the small bursts of current that convey the information.

Cameras with larger sensors and better lenses normally take better shots, regardless of the megapixel count. Bigger sensors normally create better images, as do higher-quality lenses. Therefore it is important to check the size of the sensor of the camera you are planning to buy.

Although it is also available on some point-and-shoot cameras, sensor stabilisation is more commonly used in DSLRs. With sensor stabilisation, gyroscopes located in the camera body, rather than the lenses, detect shake and then move the image sensor to counteract motion.

Flash

It is important to know the type of flash the chosen DSLR camera has and how much control it gives over flash settings. DSLRs usually have inbuilt flash; some have a hot-shoe mount or a bracket that lets you attach an external flash to the camera, while some have both. If a camera has a mount but no flash, check to see if an external flash is included as part of the kit or whether you would need to buy it separately.

The inbuilt flash can be extremely handy to have, but it would not be of as high quality as an external flash. For casual photography, the inbuilt flash could be useful, but for professional use, a hot-shoe mount would work better.

Another point to be considered is quick access to different flash modes. Make sure the camera you buy gives you quick access to different flash modes, including On (forces the flash to fire even if the camera detects enough light, which can be useful for back-lighting situations), Off (prevents your flash from firing even in low-light situations) and Slow-Sync (also referred to as night-time mode). ●

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SHAVISON ELECTRONICS PVT. LTD.

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 Telefax: +91-251-26204171/2620427 Cell: +91 98 203 62890

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